"I would wish that the rooms for solitary confinement at night were not too small, and would plead for the cheering influence of light, as well as of air, in them. The lazaretto at Zante came up to my ideas of the construction of a penitentiary house, or house of correction, more, I think, than any building I have yet seen. It also had that exposure to the salutary influence of the breezes, and that cheerfulness of aspect, which are so necessary to relieve the languor attending sickness and confinement.

"I conclude this subject in the words of an elegant writer, in the prefatory observations on a draught of a Bill to punish by imprisonment and hard labour, etc., that, 'if a beginning be once made, by adopting such a plan as may appear the least liable to objections (for none can be entirely free from them) it must be left to time, experience, and the wisdom of subsequent sessions, to revise, improve, and mature it. Many useful and essential amendments may, even at present, be expected from others who will give their immediate attention: and much must ultimately depend on the active, judicious, and discreet concurrence of magistrates and gentlemen of weight in the different parts of the kingdom: for it will be impossible, in the first introduction of so great an establishment, to foresee and prescribe the whole detail of rules necessary to be observed; and indeed it will be better, in every respect, to leave that detail, under proper checks and restrictions, to be hereafter planned and settled in the several districts to be established.'"

[From *An Account of Lazarettos*, pp. 226–30.]

CONCLUSION

To The State of the Prisons

It was once my intention to have published the preceding account of English prisons, without any of the introductory matter which composes the former part of this volume. But thinking, from a close attention to the subject, that it was in my power in some instances to suggest remedies to the evils of which I had been witness; and aware of the common proverbial objection "that it is easier to find faults than to mend them"; I imagined I should be culpable in suppressing anything which might conduce to improvement in a matter I had so much at heart.

A person of more ability, with my knowledge of facts, would have written better: but the object of my ambition was not the fame of an author. Hearing the cry of the miserable, I devoted my time to their relief. In order to procure it, I made it my business to collect materials, the authenticity of which could not be disputed. For the warmth of some expressions where my subject obliges me to complain, and for my eagerness to remove the several grievances, my apology must be drawn from the deep distress of the sufferers, and the impression the view of it made upon me—an impression too deep to be effaced by any length of time!

What I have proposed throughout my work is liable, I am sensible, to some objections; and these will, doubtless, be heightened by the cavils of those whose interest it is to prevent the reformation of abuses on which their ease or emolument may depend. Yet I hope not to be entirely deserted in the conflict: and if this publication should be the means of exciting the attention of my countrymen to this important national concern—of alleviating the distresses of poor debtors and other prisoners; of procuring for them cleanly and wholesome abodes, and exterminating the gaol-fever, which has so often spread abroad its dreadful contagion; of abolishing, or at least reducing, the oppressive fees of clerks of assize, and of the peace; of preventing the sale of liquors in prisons; of checking the impositions of gaolers, and the extortions of bailiffs; of introducing a